

ILIKEITDEEP · A GUIDED JOURNAL

I Was There Too

*A Journal for Those Who Grew Up With an
Addicted Parent*



printable pdf · 18 guided questions · your side of the story

WELCOME

Before You Begin



Everyone talks about the addict's story — the struggle, the rock bottom, the recovery. But you were in that house too. Watching. Waiting. Growing up in the middle of it. Your story matters just as much.

This journal is your side. The childhood you actually had, the things you saw, the words you swallowed, and the patterns you carried out the front door into adulthood.

Two truths to carry through every page:
It was never your fault. And you could not have saved them.

This is heavy work. Support groups exist just for people like you — grown children of addiction — and a therapist can help carry the weight. Please don't do this alone if it gets big. You've been alone with it long enough.

STARTING POINT

The House I Grew Up In



Describe what home actually felt like — the walking on eggshells, the good days, the waiting. Write the truth you never got to say out loud.

PART ONE

What It Was Like



*Your memories are valid, even the ones others
deny or 'don't remember.'*

What's your earliest memory of knowing something was wrong — even before you had words for it?



What did you become in that house — the caretaker, the peacekeeper, the perfect one, the ghost? What did that role cost you?



What did you watch for? The footsteps, the tone of voice, the look in their eyes — write about living on alert.



What moments do you carry that no one ever acknowledged — the missed events, the scary nights, the broken promises?



What did you tell people back then? What was the cover story, and what did keeping it teach you?



Where were the other adults? Write about who saw and helped — and who saw and didn't.



PART TWO

What I Wish I Could Have Said



*The child in that house had words. Let her
finally say them.*

Write to your parent in their active addiction: what did watching them do to you? Say all of it.



What did you need from them that the addiction took instead? Name everything — the small things count most.



What questions did you never get to ask? Ask them all here: the whys, the how-could-yous, the did-you-even-notice-mes.



*What did you love about them anyway? It's allowed.
Write about the parent who showed up sometimes,
and how confusing that was.*



Write what you'd say to them now — whether they're in recovery, still using, distant, or gone.



Now write to little you, back in that house. What does she need to hear from someone who finally understands?



PART THREE

Reclaiming My Life Now



*Their addiction wrote your childhood. It
doesn't get to write the rest.*

How does that childhood show up in you today — the over-responsibility, the trust issues, the need to control, the caretaking?



*What relationship with your parent — close, careful,
distant, or none — actually protects your peace?
You're allowed to choose it.*



Say it in your own words and see how it feels: 'It wasn't my fault. I couldn't have saved them.' What comes up?



What patterns are you determined not to repeat — and what do you do instead when you feel them pulling?



*Who are you outside of what happened to you?
Write about the parts of you that are yours, not the
house's.*



*Write yourself permission for the things that house
never allowed — rest, softness, mistakes, joy, asking
for help.*



For the Days the Past Knocks



Old houses have long shadows. Check your handholds for the days it follows you.

- ☐ Name it: 'that's the old house talking, not today'
- ☐ It wasn't my fault — say it out loud, even quietly
- ☐ I'm allowed to feel two things about them at once
- ☐ I don't have to answer the phone to prove I'm good
- ☐ My boundaries are healthcare, not cruelty
- ☐ Let myself be taken care of in one small way today
- ☐ Do one thing badly on purpose — perfection was survival, not me
- ☐ Text or meet someone who feels like safety
- ☐ Comfort the kid in me: the snack, the blanket, the show
- ☐ If it's heavy today, reach for my people or my support group

BONUS · KEEP THIS PAGE

Proof I Made It Out



Every healthy choice, every cycle broken, every soft thing you've built that the old house said you'd never have — record it here.

























BEFORE YOU CLOSE THIS JOURNAL

A Note, From One Human to Another



You were the child in that story, and you never got
to tell your version — until now. Every page you filled
is a piece of your childhood finally witnessed.

Read this slowly: you were never the reason.

You were never the cure. You were the kid.

And the kid did the best anyone could have done.

Whatever relationship you choose with your parent now,
choose it for your peace. And if this work opened
old rooms, let a therapist or support group walk
through them with you. You were alone in that house.

You don't have to be alone in the healing.



*You were the kid. It was never yours to
fix.*



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